SHOWCASE

8Bitdo Wireless USB Adapter

Not many of us can claim to own a Nintendo Switch, since Nintendo hasn't officially released the hit console here, but for the lucky few that do, this might come in really handy. Especially if you already owned a console before getting yourself a Switch.

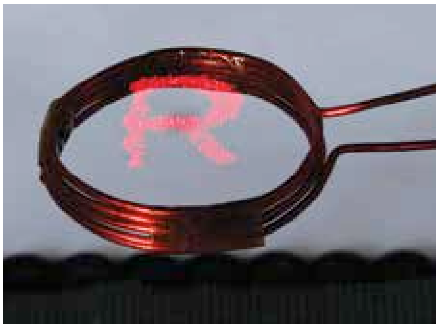
8Bitdo, a company that usually makes custom retro-controllers, has come up with a cheaper alternative to having to buy a seperate controller for the Nintendo Switch. The 8Bitdo USB adapter, which costs $20, or roughly ₹1,300, is significantly cheaper than the Nintendo Pro controller for the Switch. However, with it you can use a number of controllers with the Switch, including the Dualshock 3 and Dualshock 4 controllers from Sony.

But it doesn't end there, you will also be able to use Nintendo's previous controllers, such as the Wii remote, the Wii U controller and even the Switch Pro Controller and Joy-Cons. What's the point of support for the Switch Pro controller and Joy-Cons you ask? Well, the 8Bitdo USB adapter also supports Windows, Mac, Android TV, Raspberry Pi, and Retrofreak devices, so you can use Switch controllers for those platforms as well. Definitely a handy adapter to have around.

Luciola

Japanese researchers have created a tiny light, as small as, or even smaller, than a firefly in size. The tiny light rides on waves of ultrasound, making it float. This resemblance to the firefly prompted them to name the light Luciola.

In terms of dimensions, Luciola is as light as 16.2 milligrams and has a diameter of 3.5 millimeters. It emits a dim red light, that's barely enough to illuminate small bits of text. Of course, you can have many Luciola working together and forming shapes of floating light in the sky.



Keeping the tiny lights afloat are 285 microspeakers that are emitting ultrasonic waves. The tiny lights are practically floating on these waves. The waves that hold the light up are also on a frequency inaudible to human ears, so to us, Luciola is working in complete silence.

Makoto Takamiya, the circuit design specialist for the Luciola said it took them two years to get this far, but the light isn't expected to be commercially viable for another five to ten years.

The intended use is for Luciola to be able to function with Internet of Things, and can be used to make moving displays and even delivers messages thanks to its movement and temperature sensors.

Snakeskin Soft Robot

Created by scientists at Harvard University, on the surface the snakeskin soft robot looks just like a rubber tube. It actually is just a silicone rubber tube for that matter. However, it has special skin, which pretty much allows the robot to slither or crawl forward like a snake.

The skin is a thin plastic sheet stretched over the tube that's been cut with laser. The cuts on the skin have been made to resemble the scales of a snake. It moves when air is pumped into the tube, causing it to expand. This causes the scales to anchor onto the surface when the tube contracts, pulling the tube forward. It's already proven to be effective on rough surfaces like asphalt and concrete. The idea here is that the robot could be scaled down and be used for complicated medical procedures or even used during rescue efforts to get supplies to difficult to reach places. One of the benefits of

this particular robot is that the scaly skin is apparently not very difficult to make.

This isn't the first time nature has offered inspiration for a robot's design. We've seen octopus like tentacles being used for robots that grip things and even robots with movement based on four-legged animals. But how this design is actually implemented remains to be seen.